

## ***Republic and Politics***

Both Plato and Aristotle extended their theories into political philosophy, examining how best society could be organized. Unsurprisingly, each took a different approach and reached a different conclusion. Plato's *Republic* described his vision of a somewhat authoritarian city-state governed by specially educated philosopher-kings, whose knowledge of the Forms of virtue made them uniquely qualified to rule.

Aristotle applied a more systematic approach in his *Politics*. He analysed the possible forms of government, categorizing them by criteria of 'Who rules?' (a single person, a select few or the people?) and 'On whose behalf?' (themselves, or the state?). He identified three forms of true constitution: monarchy, aristocracy and polity (or constitutional government). These all ruled for the common good, but when perverted, became tyranny, oligarchy and democracy. Given a choice, Aristotle believed that polity was the optimal form of government, with democracy the least harmful of the perverted forms.

**Aristotle's forms of government**

